

ALMONTE AND DISTRICT

Town council briefs

The following was discussed at the Dec. 10 Almonte council meeting. Councillor Janet Brennan was absent. The meeting was chaired by Mayor Dorothy Finner.

Committees remain unchanged

Almonte's council and community committees will remain unchanged in 1997.

Chairs of committees are as follows:

- Alex Gillis (EDC)
- Dorothy Finner (Parks and Rec.)
- Ed Wilson (Planning)
- Garry Dalgity (Public Works)
- Paul Finner (Finance and Admin.)

Position now full-time

Almonte's recreation administrator Louis Levesque has successfully completed his six-month probation and is now a permanent employee of the town. The change took effect Nov. 13, 1996 and includes a \$1,000 increase in his annual salary.

"I think the hiring of Mr. Levesque was a good choice," Councillor Dalgity said.

Waste number set

The town will set aside \$40,682 as its share for the 1997 Lanark County waste management budget. In a memo dated Nov. 12, the county notes it expects to surpass its \$180,000 in reserves, leaving subscribing municipalities to cover the rest.

Smiths Falls has the largest bill at \$84,140 with Darling having to contribute the least at \$4,665.

No snow helps budget

What a difference a year makes.

Early snows in November and December, 1995 created havoc with the town's public works budget. With several feet of the white stuff on the ground by Christmas, snow removal bills pushed the department's budget over the top.

With no snow to contend with this year, public works director Mel Ashby reported his department is close to \$22,000 under budget for capital works in 1996.

Town buys plow truck

The town has bought a 1989 International dump and plow truck for \$37,500 plus tax. The vehicle comes with plow, harness and snow wing. The purchase was budgeted for 1996.

Lions show interest in building

Herb Pragnell has written council on behalf of the Almonte Lions Club to propose using the old land registry office as an archive.

Councillor Ed Wilson noted the Almonte Ramsay LACAC (Local Architectural Conservation Advisory Committee) has also sent a letter in this regard. That group would like to use the Brougham Street building for meetings and as an archive as well.

Both proposals have been filed at the town hall under 'proposed future uses'.

Web site completed

Councillor Wilson announced he and Councillor Alex Gillis had met earlier in December to review the final version of the town's Internet Homepage with designer Neil Brennan.

Councillors join new BIA board

With the wholesale changes made to the Business Improvement Association's board of management starting Jan. 1, council now has two representatives on board, councillors Janet Brennan and Gillis.

Council supports pledge

Council agreed to support MP Brenda Chamberlain's private member's bill (C-302) to establish a pledge of allegiance or oath to the Canadian flag.

In her Oct. 31 letter, she noted 93 municipalities "from coast to coast" have already written motions backing the proposal, including more than two dozen from Ontario.

Town contacts OPP over contract

Clerk-treasurer Des Houston told members of the finance and administration committee Dec. 4 that he contacted the Ontario Provincial Police informing them council had rejected its contract proposal for 1997. The OPP wants to increase the town's share for policing by 62 per cent from \$277,438 in 1996 to \$450,021 in '97.

A meeting between town and OPP officials is expected some time in the new year. In the meantime, the town has been told there will be no interruption in service during the negotiations.

Ski Mount Pakenham offers little of everything for outdoor enthusiasts

By Maureen Macartney-Grierson
Special to The Gazette

Mount Pakenham is back into full swing this year after a late start due to the warm weather.

"The snow-making equipment hasn't stopped since Christmas Eve. We've had a maximum of 14 snow guns running," said operations manager Mike Thompson.

Joe Kowalski, the assistant to the president of Mount Pakenham, says the facility usually has between 50,000 and 60,000 skier visits per year.

"Mount Pakenham is a ski learning centre," he said. "We focus on the family aspect of skiing."

Mount Pakenham clients agree.

"I think Mount Pakenham is a great place for families and individuals who want to learn how to ski," said Perth resident David Pock. "I used to downhill ski. Twenty years later, I've been drawn back into it."

"The ski school and the rental equipment are great."

"This is my favourite ski place!" exclaimed Pock's nine-year-old daughter, Mera. "It's fun and the lifts aren't scary."

Harriet Friedmann from Toronto observed, "All the staff know what to do."

"It's so easy to find my kids on this hill," said Stittsville's Trevor Blakely, whose children ski at Mount Pakenham. "This is a nice family hill."

"We don't have a bad crowd here," noted ski patroller Margaret Maplebeck.

The facility offers skiing instruction in downhill, cross country, racing and telemarking as well as snowboarding. There are programs for young and old alike.

No matter what your experience level is, Mount Pakenham's operators believe they will be able to provide you with a program, clinic or lesson.

"There are three zones to skiing: comfort, learning and fear," said ski school manager Betty Oattes. "Our main aim in ski instruction is to make our students feel comfortable."

"We do this by taking students into the learning zone," she added. "This enlarges their comfort zone and reduces the fear component."

Popular destination for schools

Kowalski said a large part of their business comes from school ski visits.

"We expect to have upwards to 16,000 school children at Mount Pakenham in the next two-and-a-half months," he said. "We're the most popular destination for schools due to our proximity, layout, ski instruction and efficiency."

Mount Pakenham's rental outfitting efficiency is based on three keys: asking the right questions, computer program and a dedicated installation team. Skier information including shoe size, height, weight, age and skiing ability is fed into the facility's computer program which then determines the most appropriate equipment by client, right down to the binding safety release setting.

The night before the equipment is required, the rental shop team goes into action, setting ski bindings and readying equipment. The next



Warming up

Teaching assistant Blies Edwards of Carleton Place works with level 1 students by leading them in warm-up exercises before taking to the ski hill Jan. 2. Photo by Maureen Macartney-Grierson

morning, the students are outfitted and on the hill within minutes of their arrival.

Employees and volunteers make difference

It takes about 130 trained employees to operate Mount Pakenham's facilities which include snow-making, grooming, lift operation and maintenance, ski instruction, ski rental and repair work, cafeteria services, ski boutique and front desk sales.

Staff ages run from 13 years of age and up. Most employees are from the Pakenham and Almonte area. Staff members are selected based on their ability to work with people and capability of performing different types of work.

About 30 volunteers and up to four paid people work as ski patrollers at Mount Pakenham. Members of the Canadian Ski Patrol are trained in ski and health emergency situations.

Patrollers take a proactive role on the slopes, ensuring skiers ski safely.

"We love to ski," said volunteer ski patroller Sue-Ann Blakely. "It's gratifying to help others."

Growth opportunities for people

Mount Pakenham has been a jumping board to bigger and better opportunities for many. The facility offers a popular teaching assistant (TA) program for 13- to 15-year-olds interested in becoming ski instructors.

"It's great!" said Kristin Thomas, a 13-year-old TA from Kanata. "In the morning, we meet with the Ski School Manager, then I assist an instructor with a class of six to seven-year-old children."

"In the afternoon, I ski with other TAs and help other instructors."

Oattes, the ski school manager, observed she usually receives 250 applicants for 12 TA spots.



Young skiers get individual attention as they learn the fundamentals of the sport. Mount Pakenham is well-known throughout the area as a ski learning centre which caters to families. Photo by Maureen Macartney-Grierson

On the operations side, Thompson, who has worked at Mount Pakenham for 15 seasons, says he has seen a lot of his student employees obtain bigger and better jobs.

"Some are lawyers now and one of my sons who learned snow-making at Mount Pakenham, is handling the snow-making at Calabogie Peaks," he said.

What's new this year

Inexperienced skiers and children as young as three years of age will like using the new "Handle Tow" ski lift, located on a gentle slope. This

type of tow is much easier to use than a rope tow.

Of interest to snowboarders and spectators alike, a snowboarding park will be set up next to the platter tow. The park will include snow structures with such exotic names as a "quarter pipe" and "ground toys" which will include a table top.

Make a note on your calendar to attend the Mount Pakenham spring carnival March 16. Watch this paper for more information or contact Mount Pakenham staff directly at (613) 624-5290.

YTV puts Naismith in national spotlight NBA show to run segment on inventor

By Ryland Coyne
Gazette editor

YTV, Canada's national television network geared to this country's youth, will be pointing its spotlight on this region next week.

A crew from the network came to the Naismith Centre in Ramsay Township Dec. 21 taping a two-minute segment for its show *NBA Dunk Street*.

"It's a small piece on the centre...what it is, why it is," said associate producer and segment host Steve Dykstra during a telephone interview from Toronto yesterday (Tuesday).

He said the piece will introduce viewers to Almonte and the area. It then concentrates on the centre, what it has to offer and the background behind its development.

"We also do a bit on Kory Hallas because he's from the area," Dykstra said. "Then it ends with a small plug. 'Come up and see it sometime, it's worth a visit.'"

NBA Dunk Street is a half-hour magazine show co-produced with

the National Basketball Association. While it focuses on the NBA in general, it includes weekly segments on both the Vancouver Grizzlies and Toronto Raptors as well as other Canadian profiles.

The show with the Almonte piece will run next Wednesday night (Jan. 15) starting at 8:30 p.m. The show is repeated the following Saturday and Sunday, he said.

As a "huge" basketball fan, Dykstra said he was inspired by the location and the history of the area.

"I was thinking Michael Jordan should come up here and kiss that stone," he said, referring to the rock Naismith used to develop the sport, playing a game called *Duck on a Rock* during his youth.

It's strange to imagine this sport, which has developed into the fast-paced, big money game that it is today, could have its origins in such a small "unobtrusive" spot in Eastern Ontario, he said.

"It's unbelievable...I got such a warm feeling. To think, it all started within a few feet of this piece of land."

Give the gift of life tomorrow

By Gena Gibson
Gazette reporter

Almonte's resident "bloodsucker" wants to see plenty of the red stuff flowing at Naismith Memorial Public School tomorrow (Thursday).

Joan Sealey won't really be sucking blood — she'll leave that up to the machines and professional Red Cross workers. But the organizer of Almonte's blood donor clinic hopes to watch at least 190 people come through the door to give blood.

"Some of the young people are still a bit nervous," Sealey admitted. "A couple of years ago, one of the girls from the high school set up a challenge with Carleton Place."

"There were quite a few who couldn't take it."

She said those who do give blood as teenagers often get out of the habit as they go away to post-secondary schooling.

"They're not back into it probably until they get back, and see

blood is still needed," she suggested.

Reasons for ineligibility

Some people don't realize what could keep them from giving blood. The no-no's include cancer, heart problems, high blood pressure, a history of hepatitis or jaundice, pregnancy, and some allergies. People may be able to contribute if they have diabetes, as long as it's controlled by a diet or pills.

If someone has had malaria, they have to refer to the nurses.

Sealey said many people don't know that they have to wait for a year after having their ears or body pierced or getting a tattoo. New mothers must wait six months after giving birth or 90 days after ending breastfeeding to give blood.

Donors can give every 56 days, and must be between 17-71 years of age to be eligible.

The clinic runs from 2-4:30 p.m. and 6-8 p.m.